PassFrame
TUITION

The Old Clock

Year 4 — 11+ Homework Worksheet (PassFrame Tuition)

Comprehension | Poetry

Extract (poem) — read it carefully before answering

In the hallway, tall and grand,
the old clock keeps its steady stand,
its golden hands that never rest,
tick-tocking on without a guest.

It watched my father, small and young,
when nursery rhymes were freshly sung;
it watched my mother learn to ride
her first bicycle, wobbly-wide.

It chimes each hour, deep and slow,
a sound I've always loved to know,
a patient voice that never shouts,
that simply counts the time, and doubts.

Some nights I sit upon the stair
and listen to it, standing there,
and wonder what it might have seen
in all the years it's stood between.

One day, perhaps, my children too
will hear its tick, so soft and true,
and know, as I have come to know,
that some old things are loath to go.

Questions

25 min · 12 questions

1. What colour are the clock's hands, according to the poem?

2. What was the poet's mother learning to do when the clock "watched" her?

3. Underline the line that tells you the clock's chime is deep rather than high-pitched.

4. Underline the line that shows the poet sometimes listens to the clock on the stairs.

5. What does "wobbly-wide" suggest about how the poet's mother rode her first bicycle?

6. Put these verses in order based on what they describe: the clock's future with the poet's children / the clock watching the poet's parents as children / the poet sitting and listening on the stairs / the clock's chime being described.

7. Why might the poet have chosen the word "steady" to describe how the clock stands?

8. What does the clock do "without a guest", according to the first verse?

9. Why do you think the poet imagines their own children listening to the clock one day?

10. What does the repeated idea of the clock "watching" different generations suggest about the poem's theme?

11. Find and copy a word from the poem that means "unwilling" or "reluctant".

12. Write one or two sentences in your own words describing what you think the clock might say if it could speak.